

LEADING THE WAY Gen. Anil Chauhan, Chief of Defence Staff

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Seen as an expert on China, Gen. Chauhan will also function as the secretary, department of military affairs, ending the speculation that the government was planning to split the two positions. He will also be the permanent chairman of the chiefs of staff committee and military advisor to the PM-led Nuclear Command Authority. In effect, he will be responsible for all military matters, including procurement, exclusive to the three services, barring capital acquisitions.

AN ASTUTE COMMANDER, GEN. CHAUHAN HAS TO BRING ALL ON BOARD FOR THEATERISATION OF ARMED FORCES

However, one of his biggest tasks will be to complete the theaterisation of the defence forces, which will see the creation of theatre commands. The Indian military currently functions under 17 single-service commands. It has eight commands to manage the China front as against a single theatre command of the Chinese military responsible for borders with India.

The proposal to set up unified commands came after the 1999 Kargil War, but remained in limbo partly over fears that it would trigger an ugly turf war between the three services. Air chief marshal Vivek Ram Chaudhari recently said a separate air defence command would be "counterproductive", indicating the issue still remains polarising and hotly debated.

Gen. Rawat, who was of the view that there is a marked lack of synergy between the three military wings, had been working hard to iron out the inter-services differences—a task his successor will have to continue. He planned to have five commands—northern, western, peninsular, air defence and maritime. The government also plans to create a tri-services missile command for rapid deployment of missile and rocket regiments against any hostile adversary.

It is to be seen whether the new CDS can bring all wings on board to build a lean and integrated war machinery, while working within the budgetary constraints. Going by his track record, Gen. Chauhan looks like the man for the job. ■

< AT THE CONVOCATION
(L-R) Bengal governor K.N. Tripathi, CM Mamata Banerjee and Calcutta University V-C Sonali Chakrabarty Banerjee, Jan. 2018

filed a special leave petition challenging the HC order in the Supreme Court, but the latter has reserved its judgment by upholding what the former decreed. Not just in CU, 24 other V-Cs of state-aided universities who were also appointed by similar government orders signed by senior officials might face the same fate as Chakrabarty-Banerjee once the SC rules on the matter. A PIL seeking their removal is pending with the HC.

As per UGC (University Grants Commission) norms, the first step towards the selection of a V-C is the formation of a search committee, comprising representatives of the chancellor, the government and members of the university senate. The panel selects names and sends them to the chancellor. At the latter's recommendation, the government issues a notification/ order to appoint a V-C.

For appointing 22 out of 24 V-Cs, a search committee was not constituted, nor was the governor's recommendation sought. Jagdeep Dhankhar, former governor of Bengal, had raised the red flag over such appointments for long. Earlier, to ensure a smooth transition, Dhankhar had given a three-month extension to Chakrabarty-Banerjee. Her reappointment happened before the extension period got over. The state's alibi: the governor was not acting on the state's recommendation. It also argued before the HC that the selection panel process was redundant for reappointments. Dhankhar wrote to Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee, saying the government's decision was illegal. His protests and warnings at this alleged infraction on social media fell on deaf ears. The appointment of V-Cs without intimating the chancellor continued unabated.

POLITICALLY PLIANT PERSONS ARE APPOINTED V-Cs, IT'S ALLEGED. POSTS ARE UP FOR SALE, SAY SOME

According to professors from college teachers' unions, selection panels had long been defunct since the now scam-tainted Partha Chatterjee was education minister. Under him, V-Cs were allegedly chosen according to their political allegiance. "Some were made V-Cs of more than one university. Subiresh Bhattacharya was made V-C of North Bengal University and Darjeeling Hill University," says a professor. The politicisation of education, which began in the Left regime, has scaled new heights, say many academics. Renowned educationist Pabitra Sarkar says, "The decadence we observe in current times is proven by V-Cs being implicated in education scams." Actually, both political and financial concerns govern the choice of V-Cs. "A university is flush with funds. Apart from central schemes, universities earn through selling teaching and non-teaching posts," alleges a professor. "Since infrastructure-building involves huge money, a pliable V-C can be useful." Recently, a retired professor, Ruby Sain, alleged that the general secretary of the Trinamool Congress's college teachers' union WBCUPA asked for a Rs 20 lakh bribe to promote her as V-C of Diamond Harbour Women's University in 2017. Others, too, allege that V-C posts are on sale. To do away with the convention of governors as chancellors, who as appointees of the Centre might be tough to handle, the TMC government passed a bill in the assembly on June 13, making the CM chancellor of state universities. The irony? It awaits the governor's approval. ■